

WRITTEN TEACHING

The Heart of the Gospel

A teaching on why the gospel needs a heart that complements it — from Galatians 2, 1 Corinthians 15, and 2 Corinthians 1 & 6.

Galatians 2 • 1 Corinthians 15 • 2 Corinthians 1 • 6

If a heart is not worthy of the gospel — if it does not complement what the gospel is meant to do — the gospel can appear unfruitful, as though it isn't producing what it promises. But the problem is never the gospel itself. Paul was not ashamed of it, because it is, and remains, the power of God unto salvation. The reason so many don't experience that power is not a flaw in the message; it's the condition of the heart receiving it.

Not Compatible

Think of buying a CD and inserting it into a CD player, only for the screen to read "not compatible." Nothing is wrong with the CD; the machine simply isn't built to receive it. This is what happens when a heart hasn't been shaped to match the gospel it claims to carry — the message remains true and powerful, but it has nowhere compatible to land.

Worked Effectually in Both

In Galatians 2:7-8, Paul writes that the same God who worked effectually in Peter's apostleship to the circumcised also worked effectually in Paul's apostleship to the Gentiles. The word *effectually* matters: this working happens through a channel, and that channel is the heart. Grace does not bypass the heart; it moves through it.

More Abundant Labor

In 1 Corinthians 15:1-11, Paul recounts the gospel he received and passed on. He calls himself the least of the apostles, but adds: "by the grace of God I am what I am... I laboured more abundantly than they all: yet not I, but the grace of God which was with me." The same grace was available to all, but the heart receiving it made the difference in what it produced.

The Recompense: A Heart Enlarged

Second Corinthians 6:11–13 shows Paul's heart plainly: "our heart is enlarged... ye are not straitened in us, but ye are straitened in your own affections." Picture pouring ten litres from a container into a vessel that only holds one litre. Most of what was poured is wasted, not because the source lacked generosity, but because the receiving vessel was too small for what was being given. Paul's appeal, "be ye also enlarged," is exactly this: match the size of your heart to the size of what is being poured out.

What Was Closing Their Hearts

Paul names, in 2 Corinthians 6:14–18, exactly what had shrunk the Corinthians' capacity to receive: being unequally yoked with unbelievers — entangled in relationships and practices that pulled them toward the world even while claiming righteousness. The remedy Paul gives is direct: "come out from among them, and be ye separate... and touch not the unclean thing." Only then does the promise follow — "I will receive you... and ye shall be my sons and daughters."

Blessed to Be a Blessing

Second Corinthians 1:3–7 reads differently once the word "comfort" is understood as "blessing": "Blessed be God... who blesses us in all our tribulation, that we may be able to bless them which are in any trouble, by the blessing wherewith we ourselves are blessed of God." God doesn't simply bless people for their own sake in the middle of hardship — He blesses them so that the same blessing can be extended to others walking through the same kind of trouble.

Conclusion

The gospel has never needed defending; it remains, as Paul insisted, the power of God unto salvation. What it needs is a heart wide enough, uncluttered enough, and rightly positioned enough to receive all that it offers. Where the heart is compatible — not entangled with what pulls against it, and enlarged through the same endurance that shaped Paul's own — the gospel works exactly as it has always promised to work.

In the name of Jesus.

✦ Branch of Righteousness

"I in them, and You in Me, that they may be made perfect in one." — John 17:23

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